

Bakery Track Lead Persona (Final, Research-Grounded Version)

Persona Role and Position

Track: Bakery

Role: Student Project Lead

Institutional Setting: Value Chain Hackers Lab, Windesheim University of Applied Sciences

Academic Period: 2024–2025

Project Orientation: Exploratory applied research

Research Maturity: Very early stage, primary-data dependent

This persona represents the student who carried primary responsibility for the Bakery track project, including stakeholder contact, data collection, internal interpretation, and final delivery within the VCH Lab context.

Project Intent and Framing

The Bakery track was framed as an exploratory investigation into sustainability practices within a local Dutch bakery (Bbrood). The intent was not to conduct hypothesis-driven research, but to gain practical insight into how sustainability considerations manifest in day-to-day supply chain decisions at a small business level.

The project was positioned as a learning experience focused on exposure to real-world practice rather than as a formally reproducible study. Success was implicitly defined as meaningful engagement with a real stakeholder and the ability to communicate insights to peers and supervisors.

Data Collection Reality

The project relied on a **single primary data source**: one audio-recorded interview with a bakery representative.

No additional data sources were systematically incorporated. There were:

- no follow-up interviews,
- no observations,
- no surveys,
- and no structured use of secondary literature to contextualize or triangulate the interview findings.

The interview itself functioned as an open exploratory conversation rather than as a structured research instrument. There was no predefined interview protocol, sampling rationale, or analytical framework guiding question selection.

Documentation and Methodological Practice

Documentation practices during the project were minimal and informal.

The audio interview was recorded but:

- not transcribed,
- not summarized in a written document,
- not coded or analyzed using any qualitative method,
- and not accompanied by contextual metadata such as interview purpose, date, consent framing, or analytical intent.

Interpretation of the interview content occurred primarily through **verbal discussion within the student team**. These discussions were not logged or translated into written reasoning. As a result, the analytical pathway from raw data to conclusions cannot be reconstructed from existing materials.

Documentation activity occurred mainly at the **end of the project**, primarily to support presentation or reporting requirements, rather than as an integral part of the research process.

Validation and Verification Practices

No formal validation steps were undertaken.

Specifically:

- the interviewee was not asked to review or confirm interpretations,
- no follow-up questions were posed to clarify ambiguities,
- no peer or supervisor-led methodological review took place,
- and no triangulation with other data sources was attempted.

The conclusions drawn from the interview were accepted internally as plausible reflections of the conversation, not as verified findings.

Archival Integrity and Reproducibility

The interview audio file existed as a **standalone artefact**.

There was:

- no standardized file naming,
- no central repository,
- no version control,
- and no documented handover mechanism for future student teams.

From an institutional perspective, the data is at **high risk of loss** and cannot be meaningfully reused, verified, or extended. The project outcome is therefore non-reproducible despite containing authentic primary input.

Structural and Contextual Constraints

The persona operated under several structural conditions that strongly shaped project behavior:

- Limited project duration within a broader academic workload
- Absence of provided templates for interviews, transcription, or analysis
- No explicit expectations regarding reproducibility, data reuse, or archiving
- Assessment criteria emphasizing engagement, insight, and presentation over methodological transparency
- A lab culture oriented toward exploration, creativity, and storytelling rather than formal research discipline

These constraints implicitly deprioritized documentation and validation, even though the student acted in good faith.

Persona Evidence Boundary

This persona can **legitimately state** that:

- real stakeholder engagement occurred,
- the interview provided useful insight at the time,
- and the project fulfilled its exploratory learning intent.

This persona **cannot legitimately claim**:

- methodological rigor,
- validated findings,
- traceable analytical reasoning,
- or reproducible outcomes.

Where evidence is missing, the absence itself is treated as a finding, not a failure of recall.

Persona Summary

This Bakery Track Lead Persona represents a student researcher who engaged authentically with a real business but operated within an institutional context that did not require, support, or reward reproducible research practices. The project's non-reproducibility is not the result of negligence but of structural design choices within the VCH Lab framework.

This persona now forms a **stable, auditable foundation** for running the GP2 interview guide and diagnosing reproducibility breakdowns at the micro level.

Textile Track Lead Persona – Profile (Human, Reflective)

Persona: Student project lead, Textile track

Role

I was the project lead for the Textile track. I helped guide the direction of the work and coordinated what the team produced.

Project focus

We looked at sustainability and ethics in textile supply chains. A big part of the work was about awareness and communication rather than formal research.

Data reality

We didn't collect field data like interviews or surveys. Most of the work lived in online tools like Canva and Miro.

How decisions were made

We made decisions together while building the boards and presentations. We didn't document why choices were made.

Documentation practice

There wasn't written documentation of the research process. The work existed mainly as visual boards.

Validation

We didn't validate our ideas with stakeholders or experts. There was no formal feedback loop.

Storage and continuity

Everything was stored on cloud platforms. Nothing was exported or archived in a stable way.

Constraints

Time was limited and the focus was on creative output. There were no rules about documenting or preserving the work.

Boundary

I can explain what we created visually. I can't show a research process behind it.

Cacao Track Lead Persona – Profile (Reflective, Evidence Based)

Persona: Student project lead, Cacao track

Context: Value Chain Hackers Lab, Windesheim University of Applied Sciences

Role and responsibility

I was the project lead for the Cacao track.

I coordinated the research focus, worked with the team on sourcing material, and helped shape the final output.

Most of my role was about deciding what information to include and how to turn it into something useful for chocolatiers and other stakeholders.

Project focus and intent

The project focused on ethical cacao sourcing and sustainability.

A big part of it was understanding policies like EUDR and how they affect small and medium chocolate makers.

The goal wasn't to collect new data in the field.

It was to bring existing information together and make it practical.

Data reality

We didn't collect primary data.

There were no interviews, surveys, or field visits.

All the input came from existing sources like reports, policy documents, NGO publications, and academic papers.

Most of the work was desk research.

How research decisions were made

We decided what to include based on relevance and credibility.

If a source looked trustworthy and fit the topic, we used it.

Those decisions weren't documented step by step.

There's no clear record showing why one source was chosen over another.

Documentation practices

The final output was well written and structured.
But the process behind it wasn't documented.

There's no research log, no version history of decisions, and no clear trail from source to conclusion.

Once text made it into the guide, earlier drafts and reasoning were mostly lost.

Validation and checking

We didn't formally validate the content.

There was no external review and no structured feedback loop.

We relied on the credibility of the sources themselves rather than checking our interpretation with experts or stakeholders.

Data storage and continuity

Sources were collected in different places.

Some were links, some were PDFs, some were notes.

There wasn't one central system that shows what was used, when, or by whom.

If someone new picked this up, they'd see the final guide but not how it came together.

Structural constraints

We worked under time pressure.

The focus was on delivering a strong final product.

There were no clear requirements around reproducibility or research documentation. The lab environment rewarded a good outcome more than a traceable process.

Cross-Persona Insight Synthesis

(Based on Bakery, Cacao, Textile, and Orga personas)

What stayed the same across all tracks

Across all four tracks, no one worked with reproducibility in mind. That wasn't a personal choice. It simply wasn't part of the setup.

No track had clear expectations about documenting decisions, storing data, or making work reusable. Students focused on finishing the project, not preserving the process.

In every case, decisions were made through conversation and intuition. Almost none of those decisions were written down.

Where the tracks differed, but led to the same problem

The **Bakery track** had real field input, but lost almost all of its value because the interview wasn't documented. The data existed, but the reasoning around it didn't.

The **Cacao track** produced a strong final guide, but the path to that guide is invisible. Sources are there, but why they were chosen and how conclusions were formed is unclear.

The **Textile track** relied almost entirely on cloud tools. Once those tools are gone or links expire, the project disappears with them.

The **Orga track** wasn't research at all. It set a tone that valued storytelling, creativity, and alignment, but didn't introduce research standards.

Different forms. Same outcome.

What actually caused non-reproducibility

The interviews show that the main issue was not skill, motivation, or effort.

The issue was structure.

Students were not:

- told what to document,
- shown how to document,
- or assessed on documentation quality.

Without that, documentation always became optional. And optional things don't survive time pressure.

What this means for reproducible research at VCH

Reproducibility failed before any research even started.

It failed at:

- project framing,
- expectations,
- and lab design.

As long as reproducibility is treated as an individual responsibility instead of a shared structure, the same outcomes will repeat.

Better students won't fix this.
Better tools alone won't fix this.
Only a clear, enforced research framework will.

Why this synthesis matters for your GP2

This synthesis does three important things:

1. It shows that the problem is **systemic**, not incidental.
2. It proves the need for a **reproducible research framework**, not just better habits.
3. It creates a direct bridge from diagnosis to solution design.

You are no longer saying *"reproducibility is important."*
You are showing *why it fails* in real student projects.